

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

The Wild East



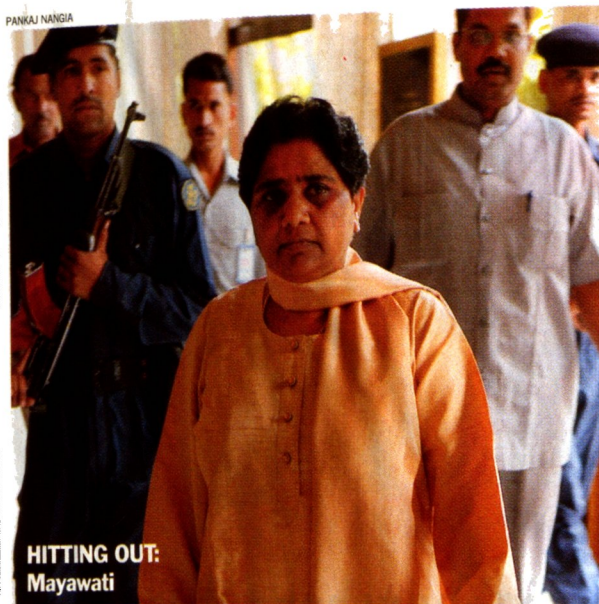
It's a great time to be in Bollywood. Its streets are paved with gold, not from individual buccaneers with dubious credentials, but by men in suits who talk strategies and business models. The money is big. Network 18 has signed a Rs 250-crore six-film deal with Excel Entertainment, which is really a tiny company run by two very bright boys. UTV Motion Pictures, which has raised about Rs 300 crore from the market, is spending it either on acquiring films (it picked up a Firoz Nadiadwala production, *Welcome*, for Rs 48 crore) or in making them (it's already funnelled Rs 50 crore into Ashutosh Gowariker's *Jodhaa-Akbar*). Eros Entertainment, which like the two previous companies is listed on London Stock Exchange's Alternative Investment Market, has put down Rs 300 crore this year on distributing 20 films, while Anil Ambani's ADAG has committed Rs 500 crore to movie production.

In this shootout in Lokhandawala, no one dies. Everyone gets a second, third, fourth chance. Flops don't matter because in the long run every film, even execrable ones like *Nanhe Jaisalmer*, make money somewhere, sometime. In this Wild East, even filmmakers such as Sanjay Gupta and Bunty Walia, who are famous for either remaking foreign movies or having famous friends, have eight-film deals. By all accounts, there is Rs 2,000 crore floating in Bollywood.



But is it a case of too much money chasing too little talent? The tough answer is, yes. With a handful of talented screenwriters and stars, proposal makers are triumphing over movie makers. Anyone with the right connections (either by virtue of networking or birth) can attach a star to a story and sell a concept. Bollywood is both under-capitalised (its revenues are still only \$2 billion a year, compared to \$18 billion for Hollywood) as well as under-exhibited (even with the army of multiplexes, India still has about 12,000 screens, compared to 65,000 for China). But it is also under-talented, which explains why we are seeing a series of films whose style triumphs over substance (*Cash*, anyone?) and whose risqué jokes pass off as intelligent comedy (how about *Dhamaal*?). The cadre of celebrities whose life is a constant red carpet may have expanded but it doesn't always translate into box office cash. So will this whole psychedelic circus collapse on itself? Not very likely, but we should brace ourselves for some quick-fix movies, because it will only get bad before it gets better.

PANKAJ NANDIA



HITTING OUT:
Mayawati

Politics of Vendetta

LUCKNOW Continuing her vendetta against appointments made by her predecessor Mulayam Singh Yadav, Chief Minister Mayawati further dismissed 3,964 policemen and six senior IPS officers from the state force after finding "irregularities" in their appointments. She had earlier dismissed over 6,500 constables. The dismissals follow an inquiry into the recruitments of 22,000 policemen during

Mulayam's regime. Mayawati labels Mulayam's government as "anti-people". Her first blow after being sworn-in in May last was directed at the youth of the state when she snatched away their unemployment allowance of Rs 500 per month, promising employment instead. On the other hand, she is expanding her palatial bungalow by acquiring adjoining buildings. **by Subhash Mishra**

New Code of Revenue

DELHI In a bid to facilitate speedy delivery of mail, the Delhi circle of the Department of Posts (DOP) has come out with a unique six digit PIN code for major bulk recipients, both individuals and organisations. Around 50 PIN codes have already been allotted in Delhi to the Prime Minister's Office, Rail Bhavan, IT-Delhi registrar, Delhi Police headquarters, Shastri Bhavan and even a high profile lawyer whose mailbox gets more than

500 letters every day. The service will start from October 1. The Chennai circle has also earmarked buildings such as Rajaji Bhavan, where a large number of offices are located. "It is a value added-service and we hope it will reduce courier traffic," says a DOP official. Customers will get better and quicker service. "We have requested selected offices to start using the new code on their visiting cards," says the official.

by Nandini Vaish